

The Revolt of "Mother"

Mary E. Wilkins Freeman · 1890

First published: Harper's Bazar, Sep 1890

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: John Constable, The Hay Wain (1821). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/A_New_England_Nun_and_Other_Stories/The_Revolt_of_"Mother" (revision 14965993), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 8–11 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Revolt of "Mother" suggest about women's rights in marriage?
- What does The Revolt of "Mother" suggest about home and dignity?
- What does The Revolt of "Mother" suggest about quiet rebellion?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Revolt of "Mother"	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*women's rights in marriage* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Revolt of "Mother"

Focus: a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home

Content note (): No significant sensitive content flagged; preview as usual.
Student preview: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

For forty years Sarah Penn has waited for the new house her husband Adoniram promised. Instead he builds another barn. While he is away buying a horse, she moves the family and furniture into the new barn and makes it a home. Adoniram returns, is stunned, and weeps, saying he will put up partitions and windows: he never knew she was so set on it.

Background: Published in Harper's Bazar in 1890. Freeman wrote about rural New England, where farm wives had little legal say over property.

Significance: A regionalist story about a woman's independence; often paired with A Jury of Her Peers and The Story of an Hour.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are sedulous, scuttled, inspecting, mumbled, cambric. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants." In this sentence it means: careful and persistent. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Revolt of "Mother" would have known. Published in Harper's Bazar in 1890. Freeman wrote about rural New England, where farm wives had little legal say over property. Why does this story matter? A regionalist story about a woman's independence; often paired with A Jury of Her Peers and The Story of an Hour. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for characterization.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "Sarah Penn's face as she rolled her pies had that expression of meek vigor which might have characterized one of the New Testament saints." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? I circle "sedulous", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find characterization, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for characterization.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of characterization. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *Sarah Penn's face as she rolled her pies had that expression of meek vigor which might have characterized one of the New Testament saints. She was making mince-pies. Her husband, Adoniram Penn, liked them better than any other kind. She baked twice a week. Adoniram often liked a piece of pie between meals. She hurried this morning. It had been later than usual when she began, and she wanted to have a pie baked for dinner. However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Characterization, Conflict, Diction / vocabulary: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Revolt of "Mother" develops the idea of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to women's rights in marriage? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
sedulous (adjective)	careful and persistent	*However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
scuttled (verb)	ran with short quick steps	*Men assembled in the store and talked it over, women with shawls over their heads scuttled into each other's houses before their work was done.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
inspecting (verb)	looking at closely; examining	*Penn did not speak of it, and Adoniram did not mention it to her, although sometimes, upon a return from inspecting it, he bore himself with injured dignity.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
mumbled (verb)	talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice	*And the old man bent his head and mumbled.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
cambric (noun)	a fine, thin cotton or linen cloth	*Nanny was to be married in the fall, and she was sewing on some white cambric and embroidery.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
bedrooms (noun)	a room used primarily for sleeping	*Those great box-stalls, with quilts hung before them, would make better bedrooms than the one she had occupied for forty years, and there was a tight carriage-room.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
profess (verb)	to declare openly	*Sarah Penn went back and stood before her husband. "Now, father," said she, "I want to know if you think you're doin' right an' accordin' to what you profess.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
arranging (verb)	put into a proper or systematic order	*He combed slowly and painstakingly, arranging his brown hair in a smooth hillock over his forehead.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
premises (noun)	assumptions an argument is based on	*The hired man had milked, but he still hung around the premises.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
retreated (verb)	pull back or move away or backward	*He added some more perplexed apologetic remarks; then he retreated.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting?
2. Where does characterization appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with women's rights in marriage?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What has Adoniram promised Sarah? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A new house
2. What is Adoniram building? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A new barn
3. When does Sarah act? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: While Adoniram is away buying a horse
4. What does Sarah do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Moves the family into the new barn
5. How does Adoniram react? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Revolt of "Mother"” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: For forty years Sarah Penn has waited for the new house her husband Adoniram promised. Instead he builds another barn. While he is away buying a horse, she moves the family and furniture into the new barn and makes it a home. Adoniram returns, is stunned, and weeps, saying he will put up partitions and windows: he never knew she was so set on it.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Revolt of "Mother"”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Revolt of "Mother"” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.” What does “sedulous” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: sedulous: careful and persistent.
10. Reread: “Men assembled in the store and talked it over, women with shawls over their heads scuttled into each other's houses before their work was done.” What does “scuttled” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: scuttled: ran with short quick steps.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Revolt of "Mother"” suggest about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A regionalist story about a woman's independence; often paired with A Jury of Her Peers and The Story of an Hour.
2. Find one example of characterization in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
3. How does the conflict in this story shape what we understand about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other.
4. In the passage that begins “Sarah Penn's face as she rolled her pies had that expression of meek vigor which might have characterized one of the New Testament saints.”, why might Freeman have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Revolt of "Mother"”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: For forty years Sarah Penn has waited for the new house her husband Adoniram promised. Instead he builds another barn. While he is away buying a horse, she moves the family and furniture into the new barn and makes it a home. Adoniram returns, is stunned, and weeps, saying he will put up partitions…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Revolt of "Mother"” set up that the rest of The Revolt of "Mother" will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does diction / vocabulary appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with women's rights in marriage? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
10. Background: Published in Harper's Bazar in 1890. Freeman wrote about rural New England, where farm wives had little legal say over property. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A regionalist story about a woman's independence; often paired with A Jury of Her Peers and The Story of an Hour.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Revolt of "Mother"” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Revolt of "Mother"”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to home and dignity: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Freeman need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the characterization in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how “The Revolt of "Mother"” treats a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Revolt of "Mother" see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve women's rights in marriage? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Mary E. Wilkins Freeman about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Conflict**: the forces, people or desires pulling against each other
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations

Chapter quiz

1. What has Adoniram promised Sarah?

   A. A new house

   B. A trip to Boston

   C. A new dress

   D. A horse

2. What is Adoniram building?
   A. A new barn
   B. A school
   C. A store
   D. A church
3. When does Sarah act?
   A. While Adoniram is away buying a horse
   B. At night
   C. On Sunday
   D. After he dies
4. What does Sarah do?
   A. Moves the family into the new barn
   B. Leaves her husband
   C. Sells the farm
   D. Burns the barn
5. How does Adoniram react?
   A. He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house
   B. He is furious
   C. He sells the barn
   D. He moves out
6. In the line "However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.", what does "sedulous" most nearly mean?
   A. looking at closely; examining
   B. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice
   C. ran with short quick steps
   D. careful and persistent
7. In the line "Men assembled in the store and talked it over, women with shawls over their heads scuttled into each other's houses before their work was done.", what does "scuttled" most nearly mean?
   A. ran with short quick steps
   B. looking at closely; examining
   C. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice
   D. careful and persistent

Answer key: 1. A (A new house); 2. A (A new barn); 3. A (While Adoniram is away buying a horse); 4. A (Moves the family into the new barn); 5. A (He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house); 6. D (careful and persistent); 7. A (ran with short quick steps)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.3, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage

your teacher selects). In “The Revolt of "Mother",” how does Freeman show a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Revolt of "Mother", how does Freeman develop the idea of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Revolt of "Mother" develops the idea of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Revolt of "Mother" (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Revolt of "Mother" suggests about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's characterization and conflict), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman uses characterization in The Revolt of "Mother" to complicate the reader's understanding of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Revolt of "Mother" within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Revolt of "Mother" alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Revolt of

"Mother" and its treatment of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's characterization and conflict, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Revolt of "Mother" as evidence for a larger claim about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home in The Revolt of "Mother". Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Revolt of "Mother" as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Revolt of "Mother".

SAT-style questions

1. *Penn did not speak of it, and Adoniram did not mention it to her, although sometimes, upon a return from inspecting it, he bore himself with injured dignity.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “inspecting” most nearly mean?

   A. pull back or move away or backward

   B. looking at closely; examining

   C. assumptions an argument is based on

   D. put into a proper or systematic order

2. *Sarah Penn's face as she rolled her pies had that expression of meek vigor which might have characterized one of the New Testament saints. She was making mince-pies. Her husband, Adoniram Penn, liked them better than any other kind. She baked twice a week. Adoniram often liked a piece of pie between meals. She hurried this morning. It had been later than usual when she began, and she wanted to have a pie baked for dinner. However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Revolt of "Mother"”?

   A. A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home

   B. A woman's brief taste of freedom

   C. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

   D. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

SAT key: 1. B (looking at closely; examining); 2. A (A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home)

Whole-book test

The Revolt of "Mother": whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What has Adoniram promised Sarah?
   A. A new house
   B. A trip to Boston
   C. A new dress
   D. A horse
2. What is Adoniram building?
   A. A new barn
   B. A school
   C. A store
   D. A church
3. When does Sarah act?
   A. While Adoniram is away buying a horse
   B. At night
   C. On Sunday
   D. After he dies
4. What does Sarah do?
   A. Moves the family into the new barn
   B. Leaves her husband
   C. Sells the farm
   D. Burns the barn
5. How does Adoniram react?
   A. He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house
   B. He is furious
   C. He sells the barn
   D. He moves out
6. In the line “However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.”, what does “sedulous” most nearly mean?
   A. looking at closely; examining
   B. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice
   C. ran with short quick steps
   D. careful and persistent

7. In the line “Men assembled in the store and talked it over, women with shawls over their heads scuttled into each other's houses before their work was done.”, what does “scuttled” most nearly mean?
   A. ran with short quick steps
   B. looking at closely; examining
   C. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice
   D. careful and persistent
8. As used in the story (“However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.”), what does “sedulous” mean?
   A. careful and persistent
   B. a fine, thin cotton or linen cloth
   C. put into a proper or systematic order
   D. ran with short quick steps
9. As used in the story (“Men assembled in the store and talked it over, women with shawls over their heads scuttled into each other's houses before their work was do”), what does “scuttled” mean?
   A. a room used primarily for sleeping
   B. ran with short quick steps
   C. assumptions an argument is based on
   D. looking at closely; examining
10. As used in the story (“Penn did not speak of it, and Adoniram did not mention it to her, although sometimes, upon a return from inspecting it, he bore himself with”), what does “inspecting” mean?
    A. to declare openly
    B. pull back or move away or backward
    C. looking at closely; examining
    D. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice
11. As used in the story (“And the old man bent his head and mumbled.”), what does “mumbled” mean?
    A. put into a proper or systematic order
    B. careful and persistent
    C. a fine, thin cotton or linen cloth
    D. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice
12. As used in the story (“Nanny was to be married in the fall, and she was sewing on some white cambric and embroidery.”), what does “cambric” mean?
    A. a fine, thin cotton or linen cloth
    B. assumptions an argument is based on
    C. ran with short quick steps
    D. a room used primarily for sleeping

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how women's rights in marriage develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how home and dignity develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how quiet rebellion develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (women's rights in marriage, home and dignity, quiet rebellion) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (A new house); 2. A (A new barn); 3. A (While Adoniram is away buying a horse); 4. A (Moves the family into the new barn); 5. A (He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house); 6. D (careful and persistent); 7. A (ran with short quick steps); 8. A (careful and persistent); 9. B (ran with short quick steps); 10. C (looking at closely; examining); 11. D (talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice); 12. A (a fine, thin cotton or linen cloth)

Essay assignments

Essay: Women's rights in marriage

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Revolt of "Mother" teaches about women's rights in marriage. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother". Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops women's rights in marriage across The Revolt of "Mother". Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Revolt of "Mother" (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of women's rights in marriage. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother". Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman's choices in The Revolt of "Mother" (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of women's rights in marriage, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Revolt of "Mother"'s treatment of women's rights in marriage in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother" that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother". Name

your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Home and dignity

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Revolt of "Mother" teaches about home and dignity. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother". Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops home and dignity across The Revolt of "Mother". Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Revolt of "Mother" (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of home and dignity. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother". Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman's choices in The Revolt of "Mother" (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of home and dignity, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Revolt of "Mother"'s treatment of home and dignity in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother" that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother". Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Quiet rebellion

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Revolt of "Mother" teaches about quiet rebellion. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother". Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops quiet rebellion across The Revolt of "Mother". Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Revolt of "Mother" (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of quiet rebellion. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother". Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman's choices in The Revolt of "Mother" (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of quiet rebellion, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Revolt of "Mother"'s treatment of quiet rebellion in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother" that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother". Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.